

GUIDE

Local Business Visibility Audit

A practical way to examine how a local business is represented across Google, Maps, reviews, its website, directories, social profiles, and the customer journey - before deciding what needs to change.

The purpose of this resource is to help you understand what is actually happening before you change anything. Use the checklist, worksheet, and audit findings as evidence, not as a reason to make changes just for the sake of making changes.

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Start with the business, not the dashboard

Local visibility is easy to reduce to a single ranking number. In practice, a customer experiences much more than that. They may see a Google Business Profile, a map result, a review, a website, a social profile, or a directory listing before they ever contact the business.

A useful audit asks a simple question: What does a potential customer actually see, and how easy is it for that person to decide what to do next?

This audit is intentionally broader than a Google Business Profile review. It looks for mismatches, missing information, technical problems, weak conversion paths, and opportunities to make the business easier to understand and trust.

1. Audit record

Field	Record
Business	
Website	
Primary location/area	
Primary service/product	
Business model	Storefront / Service-area / Hybrid
Audit date	
Researcher	
Primary customer type	

2. Google Business Profile: accuracy first

Before judging visibility, establish whether the profile accurately represents the business and follows Google's rules.

- ☐ Eligibility is clear and documented.
- ☐ Ownership/manager access is controlled by the business owner or authorized representative.
- ☐ Business name matches the real-world name.
- ☐ Location model is correct: storefront, service-area, or hybrid.
- ☐ Address or service area reflects actual operations.
- ☐ Website and phone are authoritative and functional.
- ☐ Hours and special hours are accurate.
- ☐ Primary category is specific and genuinely represents the business.
- ☐ Description is useful, factual, and within Google's rules.
- ☐ Services and attributes are accurate and current.
- ☐ Business links, where available, lead to the correct customer action.
- ☐ Photos represent the business and are reasonably current.

A profile with a factual or eligibility problem should be treated differently from a profile that is fully compliant but simply has stronger local competition. Those are different problems and usually require different responses.

3. Local search reality check

Search from a consistent, documented context. The point is not to announce a permanent ranking position; the point is to observe what a customer can see today.

Search	Observed result / map pack	Profile visible?	Notes
Business name + city		Yes / No / Mixed	
Primary service + city		Yes / No / Mixed	
Primary service + near me		Yes / No / Mixed	
Customer problem + city		Yes / No / Mixed	
Service + neighborhood/area		Yes / No / Mixed	
Alternative service wording + city		Yes / No / Mixed	
Brand + service		Yes / No / Mixed	
Competitor name + city		Yes / No / Mixed	

Google says local results are mainly based on relevance, distance, and prominence. Treat those as context for your findings rather than as a formula that lets you predict an exact position.

4. Relevance: can Google and the customer understand the business?

- ☐ The business category clearly fits what the business is.
- ☐ Core services are described in plain customer language.
- ☐ The website reinforces the same business identity and services.
- ☐ The profile and website do not contradict one another about hours, service area, or contact information.
- ☐ Important service pages exist and explain what the service includes.
- ☐ The business does not rely on a keyword-stuffed name or description to communicate relevance.
- ☐ Local terminology is used naturally where it helps customers understand service coverage.

5. Distance and service area: is the local footprint represented honestly?

- ☐ For a storefront, the physical location and map representation are correct.
- ☐ For a service-area business, the public address is hidden when the business does not serve customers there.
- ☐ Service areas are actual places served, not a wish list of nearby cities.
- ☐ The website explains service coverage in a way a customer can understand.
- ☐ A hybrid business clearly separates its customer-facing location from its service area.

6. Prominence and reputation: what evidence exists outside the profile?

- ☐ Review count, review recency, and themes are documented.
- ☐ Owner responses are present where appropriate and demonstrate active customer care.
- ☐ Relevant local and industry websites mention the business.
- ☐ Business information is consistent across important third-party sources.
- ☐ The website earns relevant links or mentions because the business is useful, notable, or referenced by others.
- ☐ Social profiles are consistent with the current brand and service offering.

Do not treat a citation count as a universal score. A handful of authoritative, relevant mentions can be more useful than a large pile of low-value directory pages. The audit should document what a customer can actually verify.

7. Reviews: read the customer language

Review signal	Observation	Evidence / examples
Most praised experience		
Most common complaint		
Most repeated service need		
Most useful differentiator		
Most common unanswered question		
Recent trend		

Review policy reminder: Google does not allow paid or incentivized reviews, selective pressure for positive reviews, or requests to alter/remove reviews in exchange for an incentive. Solicitation should be for genuine customer experiences without steering the rating or wording.

8. Website audit: the profile should lead somewhere useful

- ☐ The homepage clearly says what the business does and where it serves customers.
- ☐ Primary services have dedicated, useful pages when appropriate.
- ☐ The contact path works on mobile and desktop.
- ☐ Phone, form, booking, or other actions are easy to find.
- ☐ The site uses HTTPS and has no obvious browser/security warnings.
- ☐ Core pages load without obvious broken links, missing images, or intrusive errors.
- ☐ Page titles and headings make sense to users and search engines.
- ☐ Local details are natural and specific rather than repeated just to insert keywords.
- ☐ The website matches the profile on name, contact information, offerings, and service area.

9. Directory, social, and third-party ecosystem

Source	Correct?	Current?	Useful to customers?	Action
Major directory	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	
Industry directory	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	
Local chamber/association	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	
Key social profile	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	
Review platform	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	
Partner/vendor page	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	
Local media/community page	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	
Other high-value mention	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	Yes / No / N/A	

10. Conversion path audit

Visibility only helps when the customer can move from discovery to action. Walk the journey as if you have never seen the business before.

Step	What the customer sees	Friction or confusion	Evidence
Search result			
Business Profile / map result			
Website landing page			
Service information			
Proof / reviews			
Contact or booking action			
Confirmation / next step			

11. Findings: separate facts from interpretation

Findin g	What you actually observed	What it may mean	Confidence	Priority to investigate
1			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor
2			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor
3			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor
4			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor
5			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor
6			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor

Finding	What you actually observed	What it may mean	Confidence	Priority to investigate
7			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor
8			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor
9			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor
10			Low / Med / High	Now / Later / Monitor

12. What to fix first

Not every finding deserves an immediate project. Start with issues that affect accuracy, eligibility, customer trust, or the ability to complete a simple task.

Issue	Why it matters	Effort	Owner	Evidence of success
1		Low / Med / High		
2		Low / Med / High		
3		Low / Med / High		
4		Low / Med / High		
5		Low / Med / High		
6		Low / Med / High		
7		Low / Med / High		
8		Low / Med / High		

13. A practical audit conclusion

At the end of the audit, describe the business as it actually appears today. Avoid turning every imperfection into a ranking problem. A useful conclusion might sound like:

"The business is represented accurately on Google, but the service information is thin and the website does not give customers enough detail to choose the right service. The profile does not need a wholesale rebuild. The clearest next step is to improve the service pages, tighten the profile information, and make the contact path easier to use. We should then watch the customer actions and search visibility before deciding whether a larger change is necessary."

That kind of conclusion is more useful than a generic claim that the business simply needs to "do more local SEO."

14. End-of-audit questions

- ☐ Is the business easy to identify and understand?
- ☐ Is the information customers see accurate?
- ☐ Is the profile compliant with current Google guidance?
- ☐ Can customers tell what the business offers and where it serves them?
- ☐ Do reviews and third-party mentions reinforce the same story?
- ☐ Does the website make the next step obvious?
- ☐ Which problems are factual, which are competitive, and which are conversion problems?
- ☐ Which changes can be made without rebuilding anything?
- ☐ What should be measured after changes are made?
- ☐ What evidence, if any, would justify a larger investment later?

Current reference sources

Google Business Profile Help - Guidelines for representing your business on Google

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/3038177>

Google Business Profile Help - Business eligibility and ownership

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/13763036>

Google Business Profile Help - Manage service areas

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/9157481>

Google Business Profile Help - Manage your business address

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/2853879>

Google Business Profile Help - Local ranking guidance

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/7091>

Google Business Profile Help - Performance and insights

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/9918094>

Google Maps User-Generated Content Policy - Fake engagement

<https://support.google.com/contributionpolicy/answer/7400114>

Google Search Central - LocalBusiness structured data

<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/structured-data/local-business>

Prepared September 24, 2026. Google may change product features or policies after publication; check the linked documentation before making a compliance-sensitive change.